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Leah

The unloved wife whom God saw, mother of Judah and Levi.

Leah was the elder daughter of Laban and the first wife of Jacob. She did not choose her marriage. Her father slipped her into the wedding in place of her sister Rachel, and Jacob made no secret that he loved Rachel more. Yet Genesis says the LORD saw that Leah was unloved and gave her children. Her sons' names tell her story, moving from longing for her husband's love to simple praise of God. Leah became the mother of six of Israel's twelve tribes, including Levi, the tribe of the priests, and Judah, the tribe of David and of Jesus. She was buried in the family tomb beside Abraham, Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, where Jacob later asked to be buried too.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Le'ah</i> . Its meaning is uncertain; "weary" and "wild cow" are common suggestions
Family	Elder daughter of Laban; sister of Rachel; wife of Jacob (Genesis 29:16, 23)
Children	Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun and a daughter, Dinah (Genesis 35:23; 30:21)
Her maid	Zilpah, mother of Gad and Asher (Genesis 29:24; 30:9–13)
Key places	Haran; Canaan; the cave of Machpelah (Genesis 49:31)
Main passages	Genesis 29:16–35; 30:9–21; 31:4–16; 49:31
New Testament	Not named

"And she conceived again, and bare a son: and she said, Now will I praise the LORD: therefore she called his name Judah; and left bearing."

Genesis 29:35, KJV

The life of Leah

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Leah. The order below follows the text. Her children were born during Jacob's twenty years in Haran (Genesis 31:41).

In Haran	● The elder daughter Laban has two daughters. Genesis says, "Leah was tender eyed; but Rachel was beautiful and well favoured." Jacob loves Rachel and agrees to serve seven years for her. <i>Genesis 29:16-18</i>
The wedding night	● Given in Rachel's place Laban brings Leah to Jacob in the evening. In the morning Jacob discovers the switch. A week later he also marries Rachel, whom he loves more. <i>Genesis 29:21-30</i>
The first years	● Four sons The LORD sees that Leah is unloved and opens her womb. She bears Reuben, Simeon, Levi and Judah, naming each one from her heart. <i>Genesis 29:31-35</i>
Later	● Zilpah's sons When Leah stops having children, she gives her maid Zilpah to Jacob, as Rachel had done with Bilhah. Zilpah bears Gad and Asher, and Leah names them. <i>Genesis 30:9-13</i>
Wheat harvest	● More children Leah trades Reuben's mandrakes to Rachel. God hears Leah, and she bears Issachar and Zebulun, and later a daughter, Dinah. <i>Genesis 30:14-21</i>
Leaving Haran	● Stands with Jacob Jacob calls Leah and Rachel to the field. The sisters agree that their father has treated them as strangers, and they leave with Jacob. <i>Genesis 31:4-17</i>
Before Jacob goes to Egypt	● Buried at Machpelah Genesis does not record her death. Near the end of his life, Jacob says, "there I buried Leah," in the family tomb. <i>Genesis 49:29-31</i>

Key activities

"Tender eyed" in Genesis 29:17 translates a Hebrew word meaning soft, delicate or weak. Some take it as a compliment (gentle eyes) and others as a flaw (weak or dull eyes). The text does not settle it.

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- 1 Kept quiet in her father's scheme.** She went along with Laban's switch on the wedding night. Genesis records nothing she said. *Genesis 29:23-25*
 - 2 Hoped for her husband's love.** At Reuben's birth she said, "now therefore my husband will love me." *Genesis 29:32*
 - 3 Knew that God had heard.** She named Simeon because the LORD had heard that she was unloved. *Genesis 29:33*
 - 4 Turned to praise.** At Judah's birth she said simply, "Now will I praise the LORD." *Genesis 29:35*
 - 5 Competed with her sister.** She gave Zilpah to Jacob, and she and Rachel struggled over Jacob and over children. *Genesis 30:9-16*
 - 6 Was heard by God again.** "And God hearkened unto Leah," and she bore Issachar and Zebulun. *Genesis 30:17-20*
 - 7 Chose to leave with Jacob.** With Rachel she answered, "whatsoever God hath said unto thee, do." *Genesis 31:14-16*
 - 8 Was honored in the family tomb.** Jacob buried her at Machpelah, the place he chose for his own burial. *Genesis 49:31*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Leah.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:16–31:55	The main account of her life in Haran
Genesis 33:1–2, 7	Second in line when Jacob meets Esau
Genesis 35:23; 46:15	Her sons listed among the sons of Israel
Genesis 49:31	"And there I buried Leah"
Ruth 4:11	"Like Rachel and like Leah," builders of Israel's house
Echo: Genesis 49:10	Kings to come from her son Judah

New Testament

Hebrews 7:14	"Our Lord sprang out of Juda," Leah's son
Echo: Revelation 5:5	"The Lion of the tribe of Juda"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Read the names of Leah's sons (Genesis 29:32–35). How does her focus change from Reuben to Judah?
2. *Understand:* The LORD "saw" that Leah was unloved (Genesis 29:31). What does this show about how God sees people?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to earn love that cannot be earned?
4. *Apply:* Who around you might feel unseen, and how could you notice them this week?